Charan (meaning spy) was my new name in Malayalam. I rarely stepped out, but the few times I had to, the name was mentioned in more than a whisper. Neither of the main political parties, the Congress and the CPM, dared to question the logic of the police or the IB. Lower rung politicians, who routinely talk at wayside meetings as a pastime, ran out of politically significant matters found interest in the ISRO spy case.

Stirred they must be by one such wayside political buffoon, a group of trade unionists came with an effigy to be burned in front of my house. They came shouting slogans against the *charan*. My wife begged with me to keep silent, but I lost my cool. I opened the door and walked on to the road. The sloganeering stopped.

'Who is the *charan* here?' I shouted.

I abused their leaders and asked them to go to their puppeteers and ask them if they knew anything about what they were telling you. The group dispersed.

The Antony faction of the Congress in Kerala, led by Oommen Chandy, was going full steam with the spy tales in a bid to pull down the K Karunakaran Government.

Years later, Cherian Philip, then a Youth Congress leader and a co-conspirator of Chandy, confessed through a television interview how Chandy assigned him to link inspector general of police Raman Srivastava, considered close to the Chief Minister, with the spy case. Philip told an interview—first to journalist Rajasekharan Nair and later to Malayalam satellite channel Asianet—that he and another Congress leader were accommodated in a rented house near Trivandrum Medical College where they regularly fed Malayalam journalists with fresh fictitious tales every day.

When Philip & Co ran out of fiction, young reporters cooked up their bit about the mediators, middlemen and methods through which Sasi and I handed over rocket blueprints to Pakistan. Not to be left behind, their seniors fabricated more wonderful versions of the smuggling. One said drawings of cryogenic engines were smuggled out in fish baskets.